

as a dark speck upon the ocean, gilded along noiselessly, avoiding the use of their oars for fear of being heard, and gained the nearest land.

Scarcely had it touched the ground when a single man jumped out of the boat, after having given a brief order, in a manner which denoted the habit of commanding. In consequence of this order, several muskets immediately glittered in the feeble light reflected from that mirror of the heavens, the sea; and the oblong bale of which we spoke, containing no doubt some contraband object, was transported to land, with infinite precautions. Immediately after that, the man who had landed first, set off at a rapid pace diagonally towards the village of Scheveningen, directing his course to the nearest point of the wood. When there, he sought for that house already described as the temporary residence—and a very humble residence—of him who was styled by courtesy king of England.

All were asleep there, as everywhere else, only a large dog, of the race of those which the fishermen of Scheveningen harness to little carts to carry fish to the Hague, began to bark formidably as soon as the stranger's steps were audible beneath the windows. But the watchfulness, instead of alarming the newly-landed man, appeared, on the contrary, to give him great joy, for his voice might perhaps have proved insufficient to rouse the people of the house, whilst, with an auxiliary of that sort, his voice became almost useless. The stranger waited, then, till these reiterated and sonorous barkings should, according to all probability, have produced their effect, and then he ventured a summons. On hearing his voice, the dog began to roar with such violence that another voice was soon heard from the interior, quieting the dog. With that the dog was quieted.

'What do you want?' asked that voice, at the same time weak, broken, and civil.

'I want his majesty King Charles II, king of England,' said the stranger.

'What do you want with him?'

'I want to speak with him.'

'Who are you?'

'Ah! *Mordieux!* you ask too much; I don't like talking through doors.'

'Only tell me your name.'

'I don't like to declare my name in the open air, either; besides, you may be sure I shall not eat your dog, and I hope to God he will be as reserved with respect to me.'

'You bring news, perhaps, monsieur, do you not?' replied the voice, patient and querulous as that of an old man.

'I will answer for it, I bring you news you little expect. Open the door, then, if you please, hein!'

'Monsieur,' persisted the old man, 'do you believe, upon your soul and conscience, that your news is worth waking the king?'

'For God's sake, my dear monsieur, draw your bolts; you will not be sorry, I swear, for the trouble it will give you. I am worth my weight in gold, parole d'honneur!'

'Monsieur, I cannot open the door till you have told me your name.'

'Must I, then?'

'It is by the order of my master, monsieur.'

'Well, my name is—but, I warn you, my name will tell you absolutely nothing.'

'Never mind, tell it, notwithstanding.'

'Well, I am the Chevalier d'Arragnan.'

The voice uttered an exclamation.

'Oh! good heavens!' said a voice on the other side of the door. 'Monsieur d'Arragnan. What happiness! I could not help thinking I knew that voice.'

'Humph!' said D'Arragnan. 'My voice is known here! That's flattering.'

'Oh! yes, we know it,' said the old man, drawing the bolts; 'and here is the proof.' And at these words he let in D'Arragnan, who, by the light of the lantern he carried in his hand, recognized his obstinate interlocutor.

'Ah! *Mordieux!* cried he: 'why, it is Parry! I ought to have known that.'

'Parry, yes, my dear Monsieur d'Arragnan, it is I. What joy to see you once again!'

'You are right there, what joy!' said D'Arragnan, pressing the old man's hand. 'There, now you'll go and inform the king, will you not?'

'But the king is asleep, my dear monsieur.'

'*Mordieux!* then wake him. He won't scold you for having disturbed him, I will promise you.'

'You come on the part of the count, do you not?'

‘The Comte de la Fere?’

‘From Athos?’

‘*Ma foi!* no; I come on my own part. Come, Parry, quick! The king—I want the king.’

Parry did not think it his duty to resist any longer; he knew D’Aragnan of old; he knew that, although a Gascon, his words never promised more than they could stand to. He crossed a court and a little garden, appeased the dog, that seemed most anxious to taste of the musketeer’s flesh, and went to knock at the window of a chamber forming the ground-floor of a little pavilion. Immediately a little dog inhabiting that chamber replied to the great dog inhabiting the court.

‘Poor king!’ said D’Aragnan to himself, ‘these are his body-guards. It is true he is not the worse guarded on that account.’

‘What is wanted with me?’ asked the king, from the back of the chamber.

‘Sire, it is M. le Chevalier d’Aragnan, who brings you some news.’

A noise was immediately heard in the chamber, a door was opened, and a flood of light inundated the corridor and the garden. The king was working by the light of a lamp. Papers were lying about upon his desk, and he had commenced the first copy of a letter which showed, by the numerous erasures, the trouble he had had in writing it.

‘Come in, monsieur le chevalier,’ said he, turning around. Then perceiving the fisherman, ‘What do you mean, Parry? Where is M. le Chevalier d’Aragnan?’ asked Charles.

‘He is before you, sire,’ said M. d’Aragnan.

‘What, in that costume?’

‘Yes; look at me, sire; do you not remember having seen me at Blois, in the ante-chamber of King Louis XIV?’

‘Yes, monsieur, and I remember I was much pleased with you.’

D’Aragnan bowed. ‘It was my duty to behave as I did, the moment I knew that I had the honour of being near your majesty.’

‘You bring me news, do you say?’

‘Yes, sire.’

‘From the king of France?’

‘*Ma foi!* no, sire,’ replied D’Aragnan. ‘Your majesty must have seen yondr that the king of France is only occupied with his own majesty.’

Chapter XXVIII

Smuggling



Two days after the events we have just related, and while General Monk was expected every minute in the camp to which he did not return, a little Dutch felucca, manned by eleven men, cast anchor upon the coast of Scheveningen, nearly within cannon-shot of the port. It was night, the darkness was great, the tide rose in the darkness; it was a capital time to land passengers and merchandise.

The road of Scheveningen forms a vast crescent; it is not very deep and not very safe; therefore, nothing is seen stationed there but large Flemish hoys, or some of those Dutch barks which fishermen draw up on the sand on rollers, as the ancients did, according to Virgil. When the tide is rising, and advancing on land, it is not prudent to bring the vessels too close in shore, for, if the wind is fresh, the prows are buried in the sand; and the sand of that coast is spongy; it receives easily, but does not yield so well. It was on this account, no doubt, that a boat was detached from the bark, as soon as the latter had cast anchor, and came with eight sailors, amidst whom was to be seen an object of an oblong form, a sort of large pannier or bale.

The shore was deserted; the few fishermen inhabiting the down were gone to bed. The only sentinel that guarded the coast (a coast very badly guarded, seeing that a landing from large ships was impossible), without having been able to follow the example of the fishermen, who were gone to bed, imitated them so far, that he slept at the back of his watch-box as soundly as they slept in their beds. The only noise to be heard, then, was the whistling of the night breeze among the bushes and the brambles of the downs. But the people who were approaching were doubtless mistrustful people, for this real silence and apparent solitude did not satisfy them. Their boat, therefore, scarcely as visible

Charles raised his eyes towards heaven.

'No, sire, no,' continued D'Arragnan. 'I bring news entirely composed of personal facts. Nevertheless, I hope that your majesty will listen to the facts and news with some favour.'

'Speak, monsieur.'

'If I am not mistaken, sire, your majesty spoke a great deal at Blois, of the embarrassed state in which the affairs of England are.'

Charles coloured. 'Monsieur,' said he, 'it was to the king of France I related—'

'Oh! your majesty is mistaken,' said the musketeer, coolly; 'I know how to speak to kings in misfortune. It is only when they are in misfortune that they speak to me; once fortunate, they look upon me no more. I have, then, for your majesty, not only the greatest respect, but, still more, the most absolute devotion; and that, believe me, with me, sire, means something. Now, hearing your majesty complain of fate, I found that you were noble and generous, and bore misfortune well.'

'In truth!' said Charles, much astonished, 'I do not know which I ought to prefer, your freedoms or your respects.'

'You will choose presently, sire,' said D'Arragnan. 'Then your majesty complained to your brother, Louis XIV, of the difficulty you experienced in returning to England and regaining your throne for want of men and money.'

Charles allowed a movement of impatience to escape him.

'And the principal object your majesty found in your way,' continued D'Arragnan, 'was a certain general commanding the armies of the parliament, and who was playing yonder the part of another Cromwell. Did not your majesty say so?'

'Yes; but I repeat to you, monsieur, those words were for the king's ears alone.'

'And you will see, sire, that it is very fortunate that they fell into those of his lieutenant of musketeers. That man so troublesome to your majesty was one General Monk, I believe; did I not hear his name correctly, sire?'

'Yes, monsieur, but once more, to what purpose are all these questions.'

'Oh! I know very well, sire, that etiquette will not allow kings to be questioned. I hope, however, presently you will pardon my want of etiquette. Your majesty added that, notwithstanding, if you could see him, confer with him,

and meet him face to face, you would triumph, either by force or persuasion, over that obstacle—the only serious one, the only insurmountable one, the only real one you met with on your road.’

‘All that is true, monsieur: my destiny, my future, my obscurity, or my glory depend upon that man; but what do you draw from that?’

‘One thing alone, that if this General Monk is troublesome to the point your majesty describes, it would be expedient to get rid of him or make an ally of him.’

‘Monsieur, a king who has neither army nor money, as you have heard my conversation with my brother Louis, has no means of acting against a man like Monk.’

‘Yes, sire, that was your opinion, I know very well: but, fortunately for you, it was not mine.’

‘What do you mean by that?’

‘That, without an army and without a million, I have done—I, myself—what your majesty thought could alone be done with an army and a million.’

‘How! What do you say? What have you done?’

‘What have I done? Eh! well, sire, I went yonder to take this man who is so troublesome to your majesty.’

‘In England?’

‘Exactly, sire.’

‘You went to take Monk in England?’

‘Should I by chance have done wrong, sire?’

‘In truth, you are mad, monsieur!’

‘Not the least in the world, sire.’

‘You have taken Monk?’

‘Yes, sire.’

‘Where?’

‘In the midst of his camp.’

The king trembled with impatience.

‘And having taken him on the causeway of Newcastle, I bring him to your majesty,’ said D’Artagnan, simply.

‘You bring him to me!’ cried the king, almost indignant at what he considered a mystification.

‘So be it, monsieur,’ said the lieutenant; ‘return to your abode.’
Then they placed over Athos a guard of fifty men, who surrounded his house, without losing sight of him for a minute.

The secret remained secure, but hours, days passed away without the general’s returning, or without anything being heard of him.

man, who is evidently brave, did not remain to reassure us by his presence, and to prevent our researches being made in a right direction?

This speech made an impression upon the other two officers.

'Sir,' said Athos, 'permit me to tell you, that your reasoning, though specious in appearance, nevertheless wants consistency, as regards me. I have remained, you say, to divert suspicion. Well! on the contrary, suspicions arise in me as well as in you; and I say, it is impossible, gentlemen, that the general, on the eve of a battle, should leave his army without saying anything to at least one of his officers. Yes, there is some strange event connected with this, instead of being idle and waiting, you must display all the activity and all the vigilance possible. I am your prisoner, gentlemen, upon parole or otherwise. My honour is concerned in ascertaining what has become of General Monk, and to such a point, that if you were to say to me, "Depart!" I should reply: "No, I will remain!" And if you were to ask my opinion, I should add: "Yes, the general is the victim of some conspiracy; for, if he had intended to leave the camp he would have told me so." Seek, then, search the land, search the sea; the general has not gone of his own good will.'

The lieutenant made a sign to the two other officers.

'No, monsieur,' said he, 'no; in your turn you go too far. The general has nothing to suffer from these events, and, no doubt, has directed them. What Monk is now doing he has often done before. We are wrong in alarming ourselves; his absence will, doubtless, be of short duration; therefore, let us beware, lest by a pusillanimity which the general would consider a crime, of making his absence public, and by that means demoralize the army. The general gives a striking proof of his confidence in us; let us show ourselves worthy of it. Gentlemen, let the most profound silence cover all this with an impenetrable veil; we will detain this gentleman, not from mistrust of him with regard to the crime, but to assure more effectively the secret of the general's absence by keeping among ourselves; therefore, until fresh orders, the gentleman will remain at headquarters.'

'Gentlemen,' said Athos, 'you forget that last night the general confided to me a deposit over which I am bound to watch. Give me whatever guard you like, chain me if you like, but leave me the house I inhabit for my prison. The general, on his return, would reproach you, I swear on the honour of a gentleman, for having displeased him in this.'

'Yes, sire,' replied D'Arragnan, in the same tone, 'I bring him to you; he is down below yonder, in a large chest pierced with holes, so as to allow him to breathe.'

'Good God!'

'Oh! don't be uneasy, sire, we have taken the greatest possible care of him. He comes in good state, and in perfect condition. Would your majesty please to see him, to talk with him, or to have him thrown into the sea?'

'Oh, heavens!' repeated Charles, 'oh, heavens! do you speak the truth, monsieur? Are you not insulting me with some unworthy joke? You have accomplished this unheard-of act of audacity and genius—impossible!'

'Will your majesty permit me to open the window?' said D'Arragnan, opening it.

The king had not time to reply yes or no. D'Arragnan gave a shrill and prolonged whistle, which he repeated three times through the silence of the night.

'There!' said he, 'he will be brought to your majesty.'

‘Sir,’ replied Athos, ‘I have always lived in a world where my simple word was regarded as the most sacred of oaths.’

‘This time, however, monsieur, the circumstance is more grave than any you may have been placed in. The safety of the whole army is at stake. Reflect; the general has disappeared, and our search for him has been in vain. Is this disappearance natural? Has a crime been committed? Are we not bound to carry our investigations to extremity? Have we any right to wait with patience? At this moment, everything, monsieur, depends upon the words you are about to pronounce.’

‘Thus questioned, gentlemen, I no longer hesitate,’ said Athos. ‘Yes, I came hither to converse confidentially with General Monk, and ask him for an answer regarding certain interests; yes, the general being, doubtless, unable to pronounce before the expected battle, begged me to remain a week in the house I inhabit, promising me that in a week I should see him again. Yes, all this is true, and I swear it by God who is the absolute master of my life and yours.’ Athos pronounced these words with so much grandeur and solemnity, that the three officers were almost convinced. Nevertheless, one of the colonels made a last attempt.

‘Monsieur,’ said he, ‘although we may now be persuaded of the truth of what you say, there is yet a strange mystery in all this. The general is too prudent a man to have thus abandoned his army on the eve of a battle without having at least given notice of it to one of us. As for myself, I cannot believe but some strange event has been the cause of this disappearance. Yesterday some foreign fishermen came to sell their fish here; they were lodged yonder among the Scots; that is to say, on the road the general took with this gentleman, to go to the Abbey, and to return from it. It was one of these fishermen that accompanied the general with a light. And this morning, bark and fishermen have all disappeared, carried away by the night’s tide.’

‘For my part,’ said the lieutenant, ‘I see nothing in that that is not quite natural, for these people were not prisoners.’

‘No; but I repeat it was one of them who lighted the general and this gentleman to the Abbey, and Digby assures us that the general had strong suspicions concerning those people. Now, who can say whether these people were not connected with this gentleman; and that, the blow being struck, the gentle-

by an excess of delicacy, I left last night upon the table whereon it still lies, believe me, no man says that to me which I am unwilling to hear. I am at this moment disarmed; if you pretend to be my judges, try me; if you are but my executioners, kill me.'

'But, monsieur —' asked the lieutenant, in a more courteous voice, struck with the lofty coolness of Athos.

'Sir, I came to speak confidentially with your general about affairs of importance. It was not an ordinary welcome that he gave me. The accounts your soldiers can give you may convince you of that. If, then, the general received me in that manner, he knew my titles to his esteem. Now, you do not suspect, I should think, that I should reveal my secrets to you, and still less his.'

'But these casks, what do they contain?'

'Have you not put that question to your soldiers? What was their reply?'

'That they contained powder and ball.'

'From whom had they that information? They must have told you that.'

'From the general; but we are not dupes.'

'Beware, gentlemen; it is not to me you are now giving the lie, it is to your leader.'

The officers again looked at each other. Athos continued: 'Before your soldiers the general told me to wait a week, and at the expiration of that week he would give me the answer he had to make me. Have I fled away? No; I wait.'

'He told you to wait a week?' cried the lieutenant.

'He told me that so clearly, sir, that I have a sloop at the mouth of the river, which I could with ease have joined yesterday, and embarked. Now, if I have remained, it was only in compliance with the desire of your general; his honour having requested me not to depart without a last audience, which he fixed at a week hence. I repeat to you, then, I am waiting.'

The lieutenant turned towards the other officers, and said, in a low voice: 'If this gentleman speaks truth, there may still be some hope. The general may be carrying out some negotiations so secret, that he thought it imprudent to inform even us. Then the time limited for his absence would be a week.' Then, turning towards Athos: 'Monsieur,' said he, 'your declaration is of the most serious importance; are you willing to repeat it under the seal of an oath?'

Chapter XXIX

Fear He Has Placed his Money and That of Planchet in the Sinking Fund



HE king could not overcome his surprise, and looked sometimes at the smiling face of the musketeer, and sometimes at the dark window which opened into the night. But before he had fixed his ideas, eight of D'Arragnan's men, for two had remained to take care of the bark, brought to the house, where Parry received him, that object of an oblong form, which, for the moment, inclosed the destinies of England. Before he left Calais, D'Arragnan had had made in that city a sort of coffin, large and deep enough for a man to turn in it at his ease. The bottom and sides, properly upholstered, formed a bed sufficiently soft to prevent the rolling of the ship turning this kind of cage into a rat-trap. The little grating, of which D'Arragnan had spoken to the king, like the visor of the helmet, was placed opposite to the man's face. It was so constructed that, at the least cry, a sudden pressure would stifle that cry, and, if necessary, him who had uttered that cry.

D'Arragnan was so well acquainted with his crew and his prisoner, that during the whole voyage he had been in dread of two things: either that the general would prefer death to this sort of imprisonment, and would smother himself by endeavouring to speak, or that his guards would allow themselves to be tempted by the offers of the prisoner, and put him, D'Arragnan, into the box instead of Monk.

D'Arragnan, therefore, had passed the two days and the two nights of the voyage close to the coffin, alone with the general, offering him wine and food, which the latter had refused, and constantly endeavouring to reassure him upon the destiny which awaited him at the end of this singular captivity. Two pistols on the table and his naked sword made D'Arragnan easy with regard to indiscretions from without.

When once at Scheveningen he had felt completely reassured. His men greatly dreaded any conflict with the lords of the soil. He had, besides, interested in his cause him who had morally served him as lieutenant, and whom we have seen reply to the name of Menneville. The latter, not being a vulgar spirit, had more to risk than the others, because he had more conscience. He believed in a future in the service of D'Arragnan, and consequently would have allowed himself to be cut to pieces, rather than violate the order given by his leader. Thus it was that, once landed, it was to him that D'Arragnan had confided the care of the chest and the general's breathing. It was he, too, he had ordered to have the chest brought by the seven men as soon as he should hear the triple whistle. We have seen that the lieutenant obeyed. The coffer once in the house, D'Arragnan dismissed his men with a gracious smile, saying, 'Messieurs, you have rendered a great service to King Charles II, who in less than six weeks will be king of England. Your gratification will then be doubled. Return to the boat and wait for me.' Upon which they departed with such shouts of joy as terrified even the dog himself.

D'Arragnan had caused the coffer to be brought as far as the king's ante-chamber. He then, with great care, closed the door of this ante-chamber, after which he opened the coffer, and said to the general:

'General, I have a thousand excuses to make to you; my manner of acting has not been worthy of such a man as you, I know very well; but I wished you to take me for the captain of a bark. And then England is a very inconvenient country for transports. I hope, therefore, you will take all that into consideration. But now, general, you are at liberty to get up and walk.' This said, he cut the bonds which fastened the arms and hands of the general. The latter got up, and then sat down with the countenance of a man who expects death. D'Arragnan opened the door of Charles's study, and said, 'Sire, here is your enemy, M. Monk; I promised myself to perform this service for your majesty. It is done, now order as you please. M. Monk,' added he, turning towards the

'You will understand me—and, in the first place, do not speak so loudly.' Athos smiled disdainfully.

'We don't ask you to smile,' said one of the colonels warmly; 'we require you to answer.'

'And I, gentlemen, declare to you that I will not reply until I am in the presence of the general.'

'But,' replied the same colonel who had already spoken, 'you know very well that is impossible.'

'This is the second time I have received this strange reply to the wish I express,' said Athos. 'Is the general absent?'

This question was made with such apparent good faith, and the gentleman wore an air of such natural surprise, that the three officers exchanged a meaning look. The lieutenant, by a tacit convention with the other two, was spokesman.

'Monsieur, the general left you last night on the borders of the monastery.'

'Yes, monsieur.'

'And you went—'

'It is not for me to answer you, but for those who have accompanied me. They were your soldiers, ask them.'

'But if we please to question you?'

'Then it will please me to reply, monsieur, that I do not recognize any one here, that I know no one here but the general, and that it is to him alone I will reply.'

'So be it, monsieur; but as we are the masters, we constitute ourselves a council of war, and when you are before judges you must reply.'

The countenance of Athos expressed nothing but astonishment and disdain, instead of the terror the officers expected to read in it at this threat.

'Scottish or English judges upon me, a subject of the king of France; upon me, placed under the safeguard of British honour! You are mad, gentlemen!' said Athos, shrugging his shoulders.

The officers looked at each other. 'Then, monsieur,' said one of them, 'do you pretend not to know where the general is?'

'To that, monsieur, I have already replied.'

'Yes, but you have already replied an incredible thing.'

'It is true, nevertheless, gentlemen. Men of my rank are not generally liars. I am a gentleman, I have told you, and when I have at my side the sword which,